

Figure 3: K3b and SMPlayer

and also presents a manual setting prompt.

The desktop shows the auto-mounted partitions. In my case, the distro successfully detected all the disks. The Xfce menu bar in the bottom contains the quick launch buttons, desktop buttons, the Xfce sound mixer, the time, the log off button and the Xfce menu button with the CDlinux logo. I can enter all the partitions and access the files. The 0.9.3 uses Xfce 4.6.1, which has a cooler look than the older one, with a new cursor and icon theme. The user drives of my Fedora partition were protected and could not be entered. Firefox 3.5.2 comes with the compact menu plug-in installed, which made the menus compactly fit into a button on the top left. It also had the 'Flash block' plug-in, even though the Standard edition didn't have Flash support. This plug-in is of immense use with the Community Edition (which has many non-free components). Since CDlinux loads on the RAM, the slow IDE HDD was not a factor any more. The experience was very smooth, without a single glitch or any slowdown. I have a habit of opening a lot of tabs by middle clicking on the links, and that slows down the system with my default Fedora 10 (KDE and Xfce). CDlinux allowed me to do this happily. Other than browsing, Pidgin was there to connect to chat accounts and to freenode. Mail client Sylpheed was also present. The Internet experience with CDlinux was very good and I just didn't feel like logging into Fedora again. Xfburn was introduced in the standard edition 0.9.3.

In the *Systems* section, a new addition is the TestDisk data rescue and disk repair application. You can use this to recover deleted files, corrupt partition tables, manipulate the boot sector and a lot more. Other than Thunar, the default file manager of Xfce, CDlinux provides a patched and tuned version of Midnight Commander, which Zhao recommends. In the *Accessories* section, you can find a character map, the Calculator (a GTK2-based scientific calculator), and the Xfce's mousepad and Xarchiver. The 0.9.3 version

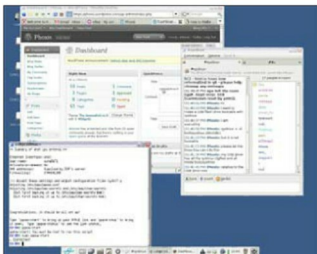


Figure 4: A few more apps

also introduces Clipman, the clipboard utility. Finally, we come to the *rxvt* terminal program to enter the command line. I tried enabling desktop effects from *Xfce control panel* -> *window manager tweaks* -> *compositing*. It worked fine without any visible performance degrade, except that when the transparency was enabled for moving windows, it went choppy. The CPU frequency scaling, a new update to this edition, adjusts the CPU clock for different loads. Change it as per your needs at *Settings* -> *CPU Powersaving Settings*.

The 0.6.2 CDlinux release contained no graphical HDD/USB installer, and it has to be installed manually by modifying an existing bootloader or installing one. In this version, I found a graphical installer that is still under development. The graphical installer is capable of installing CDlinux in a USB drive or in the Microsoft Windows C: partition. The installation of CDlinux is non-destructive and does not format or remove anything off the drive. It just copies the CDlinux files from the CD in the Windows partition and then installs the GRUB4DOS bootloader. Though this didn't work for me. If you know how to configure a bootloader, it can be easily installed manually.

The command line uses bash as shell, a patched Busybox for core utilities and lots of other programs, like fdisk, Parted, Syslinux, Grub, TestDisk, Midnight Commander, VI text editor, and wget. And oh! You can also find the 'chntpw' program with which you can reset Microsoft Windows account passwords and manipulate registry values. You need to 'sudo' to run a command as the root user, or run them in the super-user mode terminal.

The community edition

The community edition of CDlinux has all the applications that we mentioned earlier and, in addition, a lot more extra packages like Wine (v1.0.1) (without OpenGL support), Java Runtime, SMPlayer, the Gimp, etc.

The booting time was a bit high for this edition. This might be because it copies the packages onto the RAM,